Pre-Class Assignment: "The Agentic Economy"

Rothschild et al. (Communications of the ACM, 2026)

ECON 470 — Microeconomics of Artificial Intelligence

Spring 2026

Reading: David M. Rothschild, Markus Mobius, Jake M. Hofman, et al., "The Agentic Economy," *Communications of the ACM* 69, no. 2 (2026). Available at cacm.acm.org/opinion/the-agentic-economy.

Due: In person, Monday May 11, at the start of class.

Instructions: Answer each question in 1–3 sentences. These are reading-check questions — they should be quick if you read the essay. You must submit this assignment in person. The assignment must be handwritten. No photocopies will be accepted.

Why we do this: A team of your classmates is presenting this essay and leading a 10-minute discussion afterward. These questions ensure you arrive ready to participate.

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1. The authors distinguish between "unscripted" and "unrestricted" agent interactions. What is the difference?
2. The article contrasts two possible futures: "agentic walled gardens" and a "web of agents." In one or two sentences, what is the key difference between these scenarios?
3. The authors argue that AI agents could reduce the market power of two-sided platforms (like Amazon or Expedia). What is the mechanism?
4. The essay proposes a shift from an "attention economy" to a "preference economy." What becomes the scarce and valuable resource in this new model?
5. Pick one prediction or claim from the article that you found either compelling or unconvincing. State it in one sentence, then say why you reacted the way you did.